# CENTRAL AMERICA (including the Caribbean)

## OSTA RICA (3 September)

Harvesting of 2001 maize crops started in August and the earlier forecast of a 12 percent increase in white maize production has been lowered following damages to the crop caused by a dry spell in June and July. Production is now anticipated to remain at last yearï¿½s level of about 18 000 tonnes. Harvesting of first season paddy crop is underway, and production is provisionally forecast to remain unchanged from last yearï¿½s level.

Wheat import requirements for marketing year 2001/02 (July/June) are predicted to increase to 200 000 tonnes from 120 000 last year due to low carryover stocks. Imports of white maize and beans are anticipated to remain unchanged from last year. Traditionally, Costa Rica imports white maize and beans from neighbouring countries, but importers this year will be looking elsewhere following a dry spell that affected first season crops throughout Central America.

## UBA (3 September)

Agriculture was affected last year and early this year by what some have described as the worst drought in a decade. Moderate rains in July and August have improved the situation and favoured first season coarse grain, paddy and coffee crops due to be harvested from September. Early forecasts are that production of maize will increase by 15 percent from last yearï¿½s drought affected crop. Coffee picking started in August and output is anticipated to increase by 15 percent.

Rice imports in marketing year 2001 (Jan/Dec) are forecast to remain unchanged from last year at 440 000 tonnes.

## OMINICAN REPUBLIC (3 September)

Harvesting of 2001 coarse grain crops started in July and is expected to continue until early next year. Output is forecast to increase slightly from last year following increased plantings and favourable weather conditions. Harvesting of the important spring paddy crop finished in August and planting of the second season crop is underway. A bumper paddy crop of approximately 620 000 tonnes is anticipated, representing a 3 percent increase from the level of last year. A slight increase in the production of plantain, yucca, beans and poultry is also reported.

Wheat imports in marketing year 2000/01 (July/June) are anticipated to reach 305 000 tonnes, while yellow maize imports (used as feed) are expected to remain unchanged from last year at some 700 000 tonnes.

## L SALVADOR (3 September)

**The strong earthquakes that hit the country in January and February, damaging transport infrastructure and housing, and hampering the transport and marketing of produce by the farmers, led to severe resource constraints for the cultivation of third season crops in January and February. FAO, in collaboration with the Government, supplied agricultural inputs for the planting of first season crops in May and June. However, early estimates of a normal maize crop from the first and most important season have been lowered by 18 percent following drought, and aggregate cereal production is forecast to decrease by 7 percent from last year. Import requirements of white maize for marketing year 2001/02 are estimated to increase by 50 000 tonnes over last year, and which is expected to be covered by commercial imports.**

**The international community was already providing food aid from local purchases to 200 000 victims of the earthquake before the impact of drought. WFP, in collaboration with the Government, is assisting 25 000 drought affected families in 31 districts, while preparations to assist an additional 10 000 families in 29 districts in collaboration with NGO partners are underway.**